HEXLEY CHEMICALS

Permit Standard: Excavation

Document Standard 05 | Issue 3 | Owner: Process Safety | Review cycle: every twelve months

1. Purpose and scope

This standard sets out what a request for its permit type must show before an Area Authority may issue the permit, and what follows the decision.

It is used by the Permit Coordinator or Area Authority who opens a review, by the Area Authority who decides it, and by the performing authority who requests the permit, as the Control of Work Policy describes.

Each permit type has its own permit standard. The five permit standards share one layout and many of the same sentences; they differ in what the permit type covers, in the requirements of section 4 and how section 5 reads them, and in the documentation, the writing that follows a decision and the reasons that sections 6 to 9 give. A request is always reviewed under the standard of its own permit type, and under the standard of its linked permit type where it has one; a requirement in one standard never applies to a request of another permit type unless the request is linked to it.

The standard applies to every request for its permit type, whichever channel it comes through.

2. What this permit covers

This standard covers excavation anywhere at Thornmere Works: trial holes, cable trenches, drain repairs, foundation work and buried pipe repairs, wherever the ground is broken.

A dig beside a buried cable whose supply is isolated is linked to that electrical isolation permit, and the work must meet both standards.

The permit type is Excavation.

3. Who requests

A request is made by the performing authority - the contractor's supervisor who will lead the job - through the channel the contractor works in: the site portal, the contractor app or scanned paper. The performing authority answers for the request and the documents attached to it.

The request gives the plant area, its hazardous area classification, whether the process unit there is operating or shut down, whether the work is indoors or outdoors, the permit type and any linked permit type, the work activity, the equipment tag, the size of the work party, the planned work hours and the answers its requirements read. The documents attached to it - a method statement, a task risk assessment, a gas test record or a rescue plan - describe the work.

An excavation request gives the depth, whether services are located and the area barriered, and whether the sides are supported where the dig is deeper than the figure in section 4.

4. Requirements

Every requirement below must be Met for an Area Authority to issue the permit. Each requirement is stated once, in one sentence, and a request is screened against all of them, in this order:

1 **Risk assessment.** A task risk assessment for the job is attached to the request.

2 **Services located.** Underground services are located before digging starts.

3 **Trench support.** A trench or pit deeper than 1.2 metres has its sides supported.

4 **Barriers.** The area below or around the work is barriered.

A requirement is never met by a sentence in a statement, and is never waived.

5. Reading the requirements

Each requirement is Met, Not met or Not documented on the request as the Permit Rules read it. The latest revision of a request is the request; an earlier revision is never screened.

- A task risk assessment is the contractor's own assessment of the job's hazards and the controls against them, attached to the request as one of its documents. The requirement is met when the request records it attached, not met when it records that it is not, and not documented when the answer is blank.
- Underground services - cables, pipes and drains - are located from the drawings and with a cable locator before anyone digs. The requirement is met when the request records them located, not met when it records that it is not, and not documented when the answer is blank.
- Trench support is a follow-on question, decided by the depth, in metres to one decimal as the Permit Rules convert it from feet. At a depth of at most the figure it is met whatever else the request says. Deeper, it is met with the sides supported, not met without, and not documented when that answer is blank. A blank depth is not documented and asks for the depth alone.
- The barriers keep people out of the area below work at height and back from the edge of a dig. The requirement is met when the request records the area barriered, not met when it records that it is not, and not documented when the answer is blank.

A requirement that is not documented names the answers it needs, so that the performing authority can give them.

A request with a linked permit type is screened under this standard and under the linked type's, and must meet both. The documents never decide a requirement. A gas testing sentence whose reading differs from the request's is flagged for the Area Authority, and the request's answer still decides.

6. Documentation to provide

When a request is returned to its requester, the performing authority must provide this documentation and send the request again with it: a task risk assessment for the job, the services drawings with the cable locator survey, the depth of the dig, the support for its sides where it is deeper than the figure in section 4, and the barriers around it.

7. The permit document

The permit document goes to the performing authority when an Area Authority issues a permit under this standard. It names the request by its permit reference and permit type, says the permit is issued, and gives the plant area, the equipment tag, the work activity, the work party's size and the planned hours, with the depth, the services located, the barriers and, deeper than the figure in section 4, the support. A linked permit type is named with its own controls. It asks the performing authority to keep spoil back from the edge and the barriers in place until the dig is filled in. The permit document carries no figure from a model.

8. The work party briefing

The work party briefing is written after the permit document, for the people who will do the work. It tells them in plain words what the job is, where it is, its hazards and the controls they must keep. For an excavation it says where the services run, that nobody enters a dig deeper than the standard's figure unless its sides are supported, and that spoil stays back from the edge. Where the permit depends on a linked permit, the briefing says so. The briefing never gives the suspension likelihood, the expected work hours or any other figure from a model, and never names any member of Hexley's staff.

9. Why these requirements

Striking a buried cable can kill, and striking a pipe can release what it carries, so services are located before anyone digs.

The sides of a dig deeper than the figure in section 4 can collapse without warning, so they are supported, and the barriers keep people and vehicles back from the edge.

Process Safety owns this standard, reviews it every twelve months and issues any amendment as a new issue of this document, replacing every earlier issue.